Adaptability questions

Design Gurus

Every company runs this round in roughly the same way. What changes between them is the list the interviewer marks your answer against.

Named criteria

Large companies do not ask their interviewers to form an overall impression. They give them a fixed set of named criteria and ask for evidence against each one.

Amazon calls them Leadership Principles and has sixteen. Google looks for what it calls Googleyness and leadership. Others use their own values or a competency list. The names differ. The mechanism does not.

Your interviewer is assigned two or three of these criteria before the interview starts. Their questions are chosen to produce evidence for those criteria. Their write-up is organized by them.

Why this matters to you

Three things follow, and they are the reason this chapter exists.

Your story is being filed, not just heard. A story that shows three qualities and makes none of them obvious is hard to write up. You do not need to use the company's vocabulary. You do need to know which criterion your story satisfies.

One story can serve several criteria. Take a project where you pushed back on a bad requirement. You found data to support your case, then delivered a smaller version on time. That story can be filed under three different headings. Knowing which ones lets you emphasize the right part.

A gap in your set is a gap in your score. If four interviewers each cover three criteria, twelve get assessed. If you have no story for a common one, that slot gets a weak write-up. It does not get skipped.

The same story scores differently by level

Take a story about fixing a production incident.

At a mid level, the evidence they want is that you diagnosed it correctly and shipped a fix. At a senior level, the same story needs more. You must have changed something so that class of incident stopped happening. At staff level, they are listening for whether you changed how other teams work, not only your own.

The story does not change. What you emphasize does. If you are interviewing one level above your current title, this is the most useful adjustment you can make.

How to use this chapter

The next three lessons cover Amazon. It is the most explicit about its framework, and the most demanding about it. The final lesson covers Google, Meta, and Microsoft more briefly.

If you are not interviewing at any of these companies, the Amazon lessons are still worth reading. Amazon publishes what most companies keep internal. Its list is the clearest public description of what a behavioral interviewer actually scores.